Cutting back-to-school costs

Labour

Getting the kids ready for school will be more affordable under Labour.

Every parent wants to give their kids the best start in life. But the cost of getting them to school keeps going up.

A secondary school uniform can cost as much as $1,000. Then there's the cost of school lunches, bus fares and petrol for the school run. For families already struggling with the cost of living, it all adds up.

Labour will take practical action to bring these costs down and make life easier for parents.

Make school uniforms affordable

You shouldn't have to spend hundreds of dollars on expensive uniforms just to send your child to school.

Labour will change the law to:

- Limit the number of branded uniform items schools can insist parents buy.
- Let families buy cheaper alternatives from places like The Warehouse or Kmart.
- Require schools to consider what parents can afford when setting uniform rules.
- Track uniform prices to make sure costs are coming down.

Schools can still have their own colours and uniforms. But parents shouldn't be forced to buy expensive branded clothing when cheaper alternatives will do the job.

The new rules will be in place by the first term in 2028.

Bring back healthy school lunches

National, ACT and New Zealand First took a school lunch programme that was working and made it worse.

Labour will bring back fresh, healthy, locally made school lunches from Term 1 2028.

Lunches will be prepared in school kitchens, by iwi and hapū partners, or by local caterers, with funding of $5 per meal and $6.50 for students in Years 9 to 13.

That means a decent lunch for kids, one less cost for parents, and more work for local food businesses.



Bring back rural school buses

National has put extra costs on rural families by cutting school bus routes.

Many parents have been left driving further, spending more on petrol, or trying to find another way to get their kids to school.

Labour will work to restore the rural school bus routes National cancelled. Where that's no longer possible, we'll work with local communities to find a practical alternative.

Kids should be able to get to school safely, without parents having to spend a fortune getting them there.

Cheaper buses and trains and a three-year fuel tax freeze

Parents shouldn't have to fork out hundreds of dollars a year just to get their kids to school by bus or train.

Labour will cap public transport fares at $20 a week in Auckland, Wellington and Christchurch, and $10 everywhere else.

Once you reach the weekly cap, the remaining trips to and from school that week will be free. That means cheaper travel for kids getting to school and parents getting to work.

And for families who rely on their cars, we won't add to the cost of filling up. Labour will freeze fuel tax for three years.

These are practical, common-sense changes that will make a real difference to family budgets.

Cheaper uniforms. Better school lunches. School buses back on the road. Lower transport costs. Better starts now.